unguided rockets and nine Falcon air-to-air missiles. Under normal circumstances that would suffice to deal with MiG firepower and engage the Soviet jets in a firefight. But circumstances were not normal. The US Air Force was on DEFCON 2 alert, which meant that the Falcon missiles carried by the two F-102s were armed with nuclear warheads. If attacked, the F-102 pilots had no means of defending themselves but with the nuclear-tipped Falcon missiles.[7]

The MiGs unexpectedly turned back, never reaching American airspace because they were short of fuel. But so was Maultsby's U-2. He had enough fuel for roughly nine and a half hours and had already been flying more than nine hours. To save fuel he shut off the engine, making use of the U-2's huge wingspread to glide. The instructions he could barely hear from his navigator at home base directed him eastward, back to American territory. With no engine working and lights off, his cabin depressurized while his flight suit inflated. As the plane glided, it steadily lost altitude, and the prospect for Maultsby began to look like a cold death either in the air, on the snowfields of Chukotka, or amid the glaciers of Alaska.

It was then, when almost all hope was gone, that Maultsby spotted the two F-102 jets flying beside him. He was now under nuclear protection but without much fuel to spare or battery power remaining to communicate with the F-102 pilots. Yet he managed to hear their greeting: "Welcome home." They led him to an icy air strip at the radar station on Kotzebue Sound, an arm of the Chukchi Sea, where Maultsby managed to land his fuelless plane. It was a double miracle: not only did Maultsby not perish, but the scrambled American and Soviet jets did not engage in a fight over his plane.[8]

This did not yet mean a happy ending. The Soviets might very well assume that Maultsby's flight had been made in preparation for an all-out nuclear attack on the USSR. The question for Kennedy and his advisers was what to do with the pilot and his flight. Their main concern was not his well-being or the safety of his plane, which had not returned to the base yet, but the reaction it might produce on the part of Khrushchev.

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